

your website is responsive or not plays a major role in Google's indexing. Websites providing an optimal experience are ranked higher and crawled more often.

## ROBOTS.TXT:

The Robots Exclusion Protocol (REP) is a group of web standards that regulate web robot behaviour and search engine indexing. Initially, the original REP from 1994, extended 1997, defining crawler directives for robots.txt. Some search engines support extensions like URI patterns (wild cards). A later extension in 1996 defined indexer directives that robots used in the meta tags. Webmasters still apply REP tags in the HTTP header of non-HTML resources like PDF documents or images. The latest 2005 version contained the Microformat rel-nofollow, defining how search engines should handle links where the <a> element's REL attribute contains the value "nofollow."

REP tags (noindex, nofollow, unavailable\_after) steer particular tasks of indexers and bots. In some cases (nosnippet, noarchive, noodp), they provide directives for query engines at runtime of a search query. Other than with crawler directives, each search engine interprets REP tags differently. For example, Google wipes out even URL-only listings and ODP references on their SERPs when a resource is tagged with "noindex," but Bing sometimes lists such external references to forbidden URLs on their SERPs.

Although robots.txt lacks indexer directives, it is possible to set indexer directives for groups of URIs with server sided scripts acting on site level that apply X-Robots-Tags to requested resources. This method requires programming skills and good understanding of web servers and the HTTP protocol.

Both Google and Bing make use of regular expressions, in order to identify pages or sub-folders that an SEO wants excluded. These two characters are the asterisk (\*) and the dollar sign (\$).

- \* - which is a wildcard that represents any sequence of characters
- \$ - which matches the end of the URL

Beware though – the robots.txt file is public and available for everyone to see. In the case you have private information that you don't want publicly searchable, use a more secure approach such as password protection. This file allows people to view which section the webmaster has blocked the engines from.

You don't need to hire an outsider to see a distinct improvement in your website traffic. Just following some of the painless tweaks is a sure shot recipe for success and higher traffic. **d**